Lake Vellmar Research Station - Annual Report 2025

Director's summary

2025 was the busiest year in the history of the Lake Vellmar Research Station. The station, founded in 1987, now has 42 permanent staff and hosted 117 visiting researchers from 14 countries during the year.

The total budget for 2025 was 3.8 million euros, of which 61 percent came from research grants and 39 percent from the regional government. The largest single grant, 900,000 euros, funds the new sediment programme.

I want to thank everyone who made this year possible. - Dr. Ingrid Halvorsen, Station Director

Ice and water

The lake was covered by ice for 96 days in the winter of 2024-2025, compared with an average of 131 days in the 1990s. The ice broke up on 14 April, the earliest date since measurements began.

Average surface water temperature in July was 21.4 degrees Celsius. A blue-green algae bloom lasted for 19 days in August, and swimming was discouraged on the eastern beaches during that period.

Infrastructure

A new laboratory for sediment analysis opened in May. It allows the station to date lake sediments that are up to 10,000 years old without sending samples abroad.

The research vessel Tärna was taken out of service in October after 31 years. A replacement electric vessel has been ordered and is expected to arrive in June 2026.

Plans for 2026

The main goals for 2026 are to start the long-term sediment programme, to publish the 35-year ice cover dataset as open data, and to open a visitor centre during the summer months.

The station will also begin monitoring microplastics at six sampling points around the lake, in cooperation with two universities.